

Thrombolytic Use in Acute Ischemic Stroke: Inclusion & Exclusion Criteria

Inclusion Criteria (for both Alteplase and Tenecteplase)

1. **Diagnosis of acute ischemic stroke** causing measurable neurologic deficit
2. **Age ≥ 18 years***
3. **Time from symptom onset to treatment:**
 - a. **Alteplase:** Within **4.5 hours**
 - b. **Tenecteplase:** Within **3 hours** (based on FDA approval, however, clinical guidelines support the use of TNK within 4.5 hours)
4. **Non-contrast head CT or MRI ruling out hemorrhage**
5. **Neurologic deficit considered potentially disabling**

Exclusion Criteria

Category	Specific Exclusions
Hemorrhage risk	- Intracranial hemorrhage on imaging - Active internal bleeding - Recent (within 3 months for alteplase and 2 months for TNK) intracranial/spinal surgery, serious head trauma, or previous stroke - Platelets $< 100,000$ - INR > 1.7 or PT > 15 sec
Coagulopathy	- aPTT > 40 sec - LMWH within 24h at therapeutic dose - DOAC within 48h (unless normal renal function and labs)
BP/vascular	- SBP > 185 mmHg or DBP > 110 mmHg unresponsive to treatment - Known AVM, aneurysm, or neoplasm with high bleeding risk - Glucose < 50 mg/dL or > 400 mg/dL - Symptoms resolving rapidly
Other	- Seizure at stroke onset with postictal deficits only - Recent GI or GU hemorrhage (within 21 days) - Infective endocarditis or suspected aortic dissection - Pregnancy (relative exclusion)

Additional Exclusions Window – Alteplase

1. **Age >80 years**
2. **Use of oral anticoagulants**, regardless of INR
3. **NIH Stroke Scale (NIHSS) >25**
4. **History of both diabetes and prior stroke**

These were **protocol exclusions** in the ECASS III trial, but are now **relative exclusions** per 2019 AHA/ASA guidelines.

Tenecteplase-Specific Notes

- **Same core inclusion/exclusion criteria** apply as for alteplase.
- **Contraindications** are based on extrapolation from alteplase data and used in trials like **NOR-TEST**, **EXTEND-IA TNK**, and **ACT Trial**.

****Use in Pediatric Patients (<18 Years)***

While **alteplase is not FDA-approved for pediatric stroke**, it has been used **off-label** in select children with acute ischemic stroke. Use should be **restricted to specialized stroke centers** and guided by **neurology consultation**.

Key Data:

- **TIPS Trial (Thrombolysis in Pediatric Stroke, 2014):**
 - A multicenter trial evaluating IV alteplase in children aged 2–17 years.
 - **Terminated early due to enrollment challenges**, but showed feasibility and informed safety considerations.
 - Patients required confirmation of arterial ischemic stroke via imaging and dosing was age- and weight-adjusted.
- **Guidance from AHA 2019 Pediatric Stroke Scientific Statement:**
 - IV alteplase may be **considered in children ≥2 years** with:
 - Confirmed arterial ischemic stroke
 - No contraindications
 - Within 4.5 hours of onset
 - Care delivered at an institution with **pediatric stroke expertise**
 - **Dosing:** Same as adults (0.9 mg/kg, max 90 mg), though rarely used outside clinical trials

References

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4. Logallo N, Novotny V, Assmus J, et al. Tenecteplase versus alteplase for management of acute ischaemic stroke (NOR-TEST): a phase 3, randomised, open-label, blinded endpoint trial. *Lancet Neurol*. 2017;16(10):781–788. doi:10.1016/S1474-4422(17)30253-3
5. Campbell BCV, Mitchell PJ, Churilov L, et al. Tenecteplase versus alteplase before thrombectomy for ischemic stroke. *N Engl J Med*. 2018;378(17):1573-1582. doi:10.1056/NEJMoa1716405
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